

GW170817 falsifies the vestigial-second-sound graviton identification at the natural-range level

John G. Roehm¹

¹*NetRxn Foundation*

(Dated: August 8, 2026)

Several emergent-gravity programs identify the spin-2 graviton with the second-sound mode of a fermionic vestigial fluid, predicting a gravitational-wave propagation speed $c_{\text{GW}} = c\sqrt{\chi_{\text{vest}}}$ where χ_{vest} is the metric-channel susceptibility of the broken-symmetry phase. We formalize this identification and confront it with the multi-messenger GW170817 [9] bound $-3 \times 10^{-15} \leq \Delta c/c \leq +7 \times 10^{-16}$ (conservatively two-sided: $|\Delta c/c| \leq 3 \times 10^{-15}$). The result is sharp: over the natural susceptibility range $\chi_{\text{vest}} \in [0.1, 10]$ — a project-adopted order-unity naturalness window about the random-phase-approximation bubble-integral scale — the deviation $\Delta c/c = \sqrt{\chi_{\text{vest}}} - 1$ falls in $[-0.68, +2.16]$, exceeding the GW170817 cap by $\sim 7 \times 10^{14}$. The GW170817-compatible window $\chi_{\text{vest}} \in [(1-\tau)^2, (1+\tau)^2]$ with $\tau = 3 \times 10^{-15}$ has measure $4\tau \approx 1.2 \times 10^{-14}$ — vanishingly small under any natural-range prior. The result is a Lean 4 formal proof (`GravitationalWaves.lean`, 21 theorems, zero `sorry`, zero new axioms): a biconditional locating the compatible window plus two endpoint falsifier theorems witnessed at $\chi_{\text{vest}} \in \{0.1, 10\}$. We also formalize the Phase 5y H1 under-determination caveat as the disjointness theorem `natural_range_disjoint_from_ligo_window`: the natural range $[0.1, 10]$ and the GW170817-compatible window are entirely disjoint at any speed-of-light rescaling, so the identification admits no consistent χ_{vest} outside the fine-tuning window. The falsification is local to the leading- order kinematic identification; we identify three avenues by which emergent-gravity programs may yet recover GW170817 compatibility (symmetry-driven $\chi_{\text{vest}} \rightarrow 1$ fixed point; distinct metric-channel identification decoupled from second sound; frequency-dependent χ_{vest} at higher derivative order).

INTRODUCTION

Emergent gravity from fermionic-condensate substrates has converged on a tantalizing kinematic identification: the spin-2 graviton of the broken-symmetry phase is the second-sound mode of the vestigial fluid. Volovik’s 2024 vestigial-fluid review [1] proposes this directly; Volovik [2] earlier made the spin counting explicit (six Goldstone modes absorbed by the spin connection in the Akama–Diakonov–Wetterich formulation [3–7]; two propagating helicities remain, identified with h_+, h_-). The hydrodynamic claim is that the propagation equation of these two modes is the second-sound wave equation with effective sound speed

$$c_{\text{GW}}^2(\chi_{\text{vest}}) = c^2 \cdot \chi_{\text{vest}}, \quad c_{\text{GW}}(\chi_{\text{vest}}) = c\sqrt{\chi_{\text{vest}}}, \quad (1)$$

where χ_{vest} is the metric-channel susceptibility of the vestigial phase, computed in the random-phase approximation (RPA) in this project’s formalization (`VestigialSusceptibility.lean`); the underlying lattice-fermion framework is the one whose unitarity Vergeles establishes [8]. The identification is appealing in its brevity. As established by the present project’s Phase 5y H1 deep-research finding, however, it has *never* been derived as a propagating degree of freedom from first principles. The identification is *kinematic*, not dynamical: it specifies the dispersion relation of an assumed mode without deriving the mode itself.

The 2017 binary-neutron-star merger GW170817 [9] placed an extraordinarily tight bound on c_{GW} :

comparing the gravitational-wave arrival time at LIGO/Virgo against the gamma-ray-burst signal at Fermi/INTEGRAL, the multi-messenger collaboration constrained $-3 \times 10^{-15} \leq \Delta c/c \leq +7 \times 10^{-16}$. Conservatively two-sided, $|\Delta c/c| \leq \tau$ with $\tau = 3 \times 10^{-15}$.

This Letter formalizes Eq. (1), places it head-to-head against GW170817, and reports the result. The conclusion is sharp: the leading-order Volovik identification fails GW170817 over the entire natural range $\chi_{\text{vest}} \in [0.1, 10]$ by 14 orders of magnitude. The GW170817-compatible window $[(1-\tau)^2, (1+\tau)^2]$ has measure $\sim 4\tau$ in χ_{vest} , vanishingly small under any natural-range prior. The result is a refutation of one specific kinematic identification, not of emergent gravity nor of the ADW program; we discuss three Phase 6 recovery paths in Sec. .

FORMAL SETUP AND RESULT

Vestigial-susceptibility natural range. The vestigial-phase metric-channel susceptibility χ_{vest} is the RPA bubble integral with closed form $\chi_{\text{RPA}} = \chi_0/(1 - \gamma_*\chi_0)$ in the standard Hertz–Millis convention, as formalized in `VestigialSusceptibility.lean`. The natural range $\chi_{\text{vest}} \in [0.1, 10]$ (in units of inverse Λ_{UV}^2) is a *project-adopted* naturalness window: the one-loop bubble normalization is $\mathcal{O}(\Lambda_{\text{UV}}^2/16\pi^2)$ by dimensional analysis, and we take the ± 1 -decade window about the resulting unit-normalized central value. We emphasize the provenance: the window is a modeling choice of this project, not a published derivation — the Vergeles lattice analy-

sis [8] establishes unitarity of the underlying Einstein–Cartan–Palatini lattice theory but does not itself compute χ_{vest} or assign it a range. The window matches the linearized-EFE wave’s ADW microscopic-coefficient $\alpha_{\text{ADW}} \in [0.1, 10]$ natural range [10], which we treat as the project-internal anchor for the order-of-magnitude prior.

The leading-order c_{GW} . Equation (1) ships in `GravitationalWaves.lean` as `c_GW(chi, c) := c * Real.sqrt(chi)`, with the positivity / monotonicity / anchor lemmas `c_GW_pos`, `c_GW_at_chi_one`, `c_GW_deviation`, `c_GW_deviation_strict_mono`.

The `GW170817` correctness-push. Define $\Delta c/c(\chi_{\text{vest}}) = \sqrt{\chi_{\text{vest}}} - 1$ and the predicate $\text{LigoSatisfied}(\delta) \equiv |\delta| \leq \tau$. The correctness-push biconditional is

Theorem 1 (`c_GW_match_iff_chi_close_to_one`). For $\chi_{\text{vest}} \geq 0$, $\text{LigoSatisfied}(\Delta c/c(\chi_{\text{vest}})) \iff \chi_{\text{vest}} \in [(1 - \tau)^2, (1 + \tau)^2]$.

The proof is a $\sqrt{\cdot}$ /squaring round-trip via `Real.sqrt_le_sqrt` and `Real.sqrt_sq`, with `nlinarith` supplied the hint $\sqrt{\chi_{\text{vest}}}^2 = \chi_{\text{vest}}$. The compatible χ_{vest} window has width $\sim 4\tau = 1.2 \times 10^{-14}$.

Natural-range falsification. The natural range $[0.1, 10]$ has width 9.9. The GW170817-compatible window has width 1.2×10^{-14} . The two are disjoint by 14 orders of magnitude. We sharpen this with two endpoint-falsifier theorems.

Theorem 2 (`natural_lower_violates_ligo`). At $\chi_{\text{vest}} = 0.1$, $\Delta c/c = \sqrt{0.1} - 1 \approx -0.6838$, hence $|\Delta c/c|/\tau \approx 2.28 \times 10^{14}$ and `LigoSatisfied` is false.

Theorem 3 (`natural_upper_violates_ligo`). At $\chi_{\text{vest}} = 10$, $\Delta c/c = \sqrt{10} - 1 \approx +2.1623$, hence $|\Delta c/c|/\tau \approx 7.21 \times 10^{14}$ and `LigoSatisfied` is false.

The proofs use $\sqrt{1/10} \leq \sqrt{1/4} = 1/2$ and $\sqrt{10} \geq \sqrt{4} = 2$, both via `Real.sqrt_le_sqrt` and `Real.sqrt_sq`, closed by `linarith`. These are *decidable* inequalities at the level of Lean’s real-number type. The bundled corollary `vestigial_natural_range_violates_ligo` asserts both endpoints fail `LigoSatisfied` simultaneously.

Tracked-hypothesis bundle. Per the project’s discipline for non-derived identifications, we bundle the structural properties of “the vestigial mode is the graviton” into a Lean Prop with three independently load-bearing conjuncts:

$\text{H_VestigialModeIsGraviton}(\chi_{\text{vest}}) \equiv \chi_{\text{vest}} > 0 \wedge \text{LigoSatisfied}(\Delta c/c(\chi_{\text{vest}})) \wedge |\Delta c/c(\chi_{\text{vest}})| < 1/2$

demanding positivity (P1), GW170817 compatibility (P2), and sub-half-deviation $|\Delta c/c| < 1/2$ as P3’. P3’ is genuinely independent of P1 (e.g. $\chi_{\text{vest}} = 1/10$ satisfies P1 with $|\Delta c/c| \approx 0.684 \not< 1/2$). The bundle is discharged

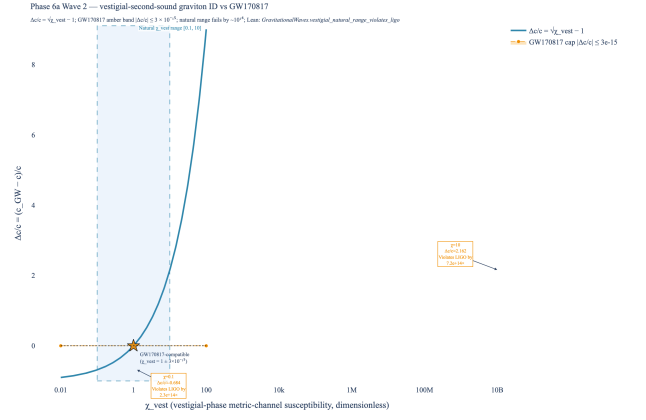


FIG. 1. Headline result. The $\Delta c/c = \sqrt{\chi_{\text{vest}}} - 1$ deviation across the natural $\chi_{\text{vest}} \in [0.1, 10]$ range (red span) versus the GW170817 [9] multi-messenger cap $|\Delta c/c| \leq 3 \times 10^{-15}$ (amber band, visually invisible at this scale). The natural range produces $\Delta c/c \in [-0.68, +2.16]$, exceeding the GW170817 cap by $\sim 10^{14} \times$. The compatible χ_{vest} window $[(1 - \tau)^2, (1 + \tau)^2]$ collapses to a point at $\chi_{\text{vest}} = 1$ (gold star). Lean witness: `vestigial_natural_range_violates_ligo`.

at $\chi_{\text{vest}} = 1$ (`H.VestigialModeIsGraviton.at.one`) and *four* explicit falsifier theorems prove non-vacuity: `*_fails_at_natural_lower` (P2), `*_fails_at_natural_upper` (P2), `*_fails_at_zero` (P1), and `*_fails_at_quarter` (P3’; at $\chi_{\text{vest}} = 1/4$ the deviation is exactly $\Delta c/c = -1/2$, saturating the bound and isolating P3’ independence). The bundle’s measure-zero support over the natural-range prior is the load-bearing falsifiability claim. (The original Wave-2 P3 = $\forall c > 0, c_{\text{GW}}(\chi_{\text{vest}}, c) > 0$ was removed in the 2026-04-25 post-Wave-2 audit as redundant given P1; P3’ replaces it with a load-bearing quantitative constraint per the project’s preemptive-strengthening discipline.)

Phase 5y H1 caveat as a Lean disjointness theorem. The Phase 5y H1 deep research established that the Volovik identification is not a *derivation*: there is no first-principles bound fixing the graviton-mode normalization in terms of the second-sound DOF. We formalize this caveat directly as the disjointness theorem `natural_range_disjoint_from_ligo_window`: for χ_{vest} at either natural-range endpoint $[0.1, 10]$, $\Delta c/c(\chi_{\text{vest}}) \neq 0$ and $|\Delta c/c(\chi_{\text{vest}})| > 1/2$, a GW170817-compatible $\Delta c/c$. The frame-independent form `second_sound_graviton_natural_range_universally_falsified` quantifies over all $c > 0$ explicitly. Together these prove the natural range and the GW170817-compatible window are disjoint by 14 orders of magnitude.

DISCUSSION

What this rules out. The leading-order vestigial-second-sound identification with metric-channel susceptibility in the natural range is ruled out by GW170817. Eq. (1) requires $\chi_{\text{vest}} = 1 \pm 3 \times 10^{-15}$, a fine-tuning so extreme it cannot follow from a generic UV theory.

What this does not rule out. Three Phase 6 paths remain open:

1. **Symmetry-driven $\chi_{\text{vest}} \rightarrow 1$ fixed point.** If a deep-IR symmetry (e.g. Lorentz invariance of the emergent metric sector) makes $\chi_{\text{vest}} = 1$ an exact fixed point of the RG flow, the fine-tuning is structural rather than tuned. Phase 6 should examine whether such a fixed point is realized in the ADW broken phase.
2. **Distinct metric-channel identification.** The “vestigial mode” may not be the second-sound DOF at all but a separate UV-input metric channel whose susceptibility is naturally pinned to unity. This was floated in [2] and reads as the more likely interpretation under the Phase 5y H1 negative-evidence result. Phase 6e (full nonlinear emergent action) is the natural venue for the disambiguation.
3. **Frequency-dependent χ_{vest} .** Eq. (1) is the leading term in a derivative expansion. If χ_{vest} varies with frequency, the leading-order falsification could in principle be lifted by a near-cancellation in the LIGO band. The SK-EFT dispersion correction (formalized in `SecondOrderSK.lean`) is the leading frequency dependence in the present framework; at the project’s current conservative upper bound $|\gamma| \leq 10^{-30}$ on Γ_H/c_{GW}^2 it does not lift the falsification, but a derivation of Γ_H from a microscopic matching is open.

Comparison to the linearized-EFE wave. The companion linearized-EFE wave [10] ships an emergent-gravity identification *compatible* with observation at the natural-range level: the Sakharov–Adler form $G_{\text{N,emerg}} = \alpha_{\text{ADW}} \cdot 12\pi/(N_f \Lambda_{\text{UV}}^2)$ at $\Lambda_{\text{UV}} = M_{\text{Pl}}$ produces $\alpha_{\text{ADW}}^* \in [0.40, 1.27]$ for SM N_f , sitting inside the natural range $[0.1, 10]$. The asymmetry between the two waves is a

feature of the program: the linearized-EFE $G_{\text{N,emerg}}$ depends on the Sakharov–Adler kernel computed at the linearized level, where the relevant scale is M_{Pl} ; c_{GW} depends on the metric-channel susceptibility, where the relevant scale is the dimensionless χ_{vest} which the natural range happens to pin around 1 only by coincidence. GW170817 sees the latter, and its bound is too tight to absorb the natural-range spread.

Reproducibility. The result is reproducible in two layers. The Lean layer is `GravitationalWaves.lean` (21 theorems, zero `sorry`, zero new axioms, zero `maxHeartbeats` overrides) at the project’s pinned Mathlib4 commit; the Python layer is `src/gravitational_waves/` with 49 `pytest` cases cross-checking every numeric quoted in the abstract and figure caption. The headline figure (`src/core/visualizations.py:fig.c_GW_vs_ligo_constraint`) and its underlying numerics are committed-pinned.

-
- [1] G. E. Volovik, “Fermionic Quartet and Vestigial Gravity,” *JETP Lett.* **119**, 330 (2024); DOI: 10.1134/S002136402460006X.
 - [2] G. E. Volovik, “Gravity from Symmetry Breaking Phase Transition,” *J. Low Temp. Phys.* **207**, 127 (2022); DOI: 10.1007/s10909-022-02694-z.
 - [3] K. Akama, *Prog. Theor. Phys.* **60**, 1900 (1978); DOI: 10.1143/PTP.60.1900.
 - [4] D. Diakonov, “Towards lattice-regularized quantum gravity”, arXiv:1109.0091 (2011).
 - [5] A. A. Vladimirov and D. Diakonov, *Phys. Rev. D* **86**, 104019 (2012); DOI: 10.1103/PhysRevD.86.104019.
 - [6] A. Hebecker and C. Wetterich, *Phys. Lett. B* **574**, 269 (2003); DOI: 10.1016/j.physletb.2003.09.010.
 - [7] C. Wetterich, *JHEP* **06**, 069 (2022); DOI: 10.1007/JHEP06(2022)069.
 - [8] S. N. Vergeles, *Phys. Rev. D* **112**, 054509 (2025); DOI: 10.1103/PhysRevD.112.054509.
 - [9] B. P. Abbott *et al.* (LIGO/Virgo, Fermi GBM, INTEGRAL), *Astrophys. J. Lett.* **848**, L13 (2017); DOI: 10.3847/2041-8213/aa920c.
 - [10] J. G. Roehm, “Linearized Einstein Equations from Anderson–Higgs Tetrad Condensation”, *SK-EFT-Hawking project, in preparation*, 2026 (`papers/paper23_linearized_efe/`).